

5 Whys

Iterative questioning to reach a root cause

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

5 Whys is a root-cause technique in which you ask 'why?' repeatedly — conventionally about five times — each answer forming the basis of the next question, until you move past symptoms to an underlying, addressable cause. The number five is a rule of thumb, not a law.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Developed within the Toyota Production System by industrialist and engineer Taiichi Ohno as a core problem-solving discipline.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams routinely fix symptoms and see problems recur. Ohno wanted a fast, cheap way to keep probing until the true cause — often a process or system flaw — was exposed.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW



Figure 1. 5 Whys framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

State the problem, ask why it happened, answer, then ask why of that answer, iterating until a root cause emerges that, if fixed, prevents recurrence. Answers should be evidence-based, not guesses.

WHEN IT IS USED

Problem clarification and quality/operations troubleshooting; also as a framing tool before ideation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Operations and quality teams, product managers, and anyone diagnosing a recurring failure.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It converts vague blame into a **traceable causal chain** using nothing but disciplined questioning — the simplest of Toyota's lean problem tools, and a gateway to deeper framing methods.

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[How Might We \(HMW\)](#) *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Ohno, T. (1988) *Toyota Production System: Beyond Large-Scale Production*. Portland, OR: Productivity Press.

Serrat, O. (2017) 'The Five Whys Technique', in *Knowledge Solutions*. Singapore: Springer.